

Research question and objectives

Commentary

General points:

Aims and objectives

Sometimes people talk about aims and objectives and the relationship between them. We could talk a long time about this (and still make little progress): in the suggested approach here, the research question stands as the overall aim of the research, and the objectives are component parts of how to achieve that aim.

The first objective

It's a good idea to make your first objective about the literature that you are going to explore as part of your research. This helps you and the supervisor to be clear about the kind of ideas that you will explore and will use to analyse your findings.

Changing the objectives

Can the research question and objectives be changed as you make your way through the dissertation process? Of course they can: this is something that needs to be discussed with the supervisor.

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Example A

This is confused.

Aims are normally seen as being broader than objectives, but these are of a similar scale. In effect there are eight objectives here, with some overlap (eg Aim 1 and Objective 2 are doing pretty much the same thing).

The danger is, with this many aims/objectives, that some are not going to be addressed (aims 3, 4, 5 and objective 3 look at risk in this regard). The researcher should think about what they are really interested in finding out, and what information they will have access to. For example, how will they assess 'if and how' the strategy is being implemented at each level? How will they assess the success of the strategy in mobilising change?

The simplest form of improvement would be to remove the 'aims' - the three objectives would just about work on their own. But whether this is a good solution would depend on what the person really wanted to research.

Best to have just the research question and the objectives - miss out any intermediate things, such as 'aims'. Best also to have a relatively small number of objectives (3-4) - eight is too many.

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Example B

Commentary

This research question and the accompanying objectives were the foundation for a very good dissertation. The question is well-focused and the objectives – at least the first two of them – are also focused on achieving an answer to the question.

The research question could be expressed a little more accurately and clearly as:

How do transactional and transformational leaders support successful innovation and change in business organisation X?

Objective 2 could also be expressed a little more clearly as:

Collect data from leaders in the organisation through semi-structured interviews with a focus on how different leadership behaviours in company S support innovation and change.

Objective 3 loses track somewhat: a better objective would have related the analysis back to transformational and transactional leadership, as in the research question. For example:

Analyse the data collected in relation to theories of transactional and transformational leadership and evaluate the impact of these two styles on attempts to bring about organisational change and innovation.

There is also a case to be made for drafting a fourth objective – about making recommendations for how best to use transformational and transactional leadership styles to bring about innovation and change.